

Special Topics:

Broadway - The History of the American Musical

(THE 2076) OER

An Open Educational Resource (OER)

RRCC Theatre Studies



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Welcome

This toolkit is designed to align with the learning outcomes and topical outline of Special Topics: Broadway: The History of the American Musical while providing open, accessible materials that provide a well-rounded understanding of musical theatre history. It includes interactive modules with practical activities, videos, suggested assignments/semester breakdown, and more.

Toolkit Structure

The toolkit is organized into sections, each exploring a different aspect of Broadway and the American musical, beginning with The History of the American Musical:

- Setting the Stage: (contextualizing American Musical Theatre history)
- Intro to Theatre (an abbreviated list of terms): (Outcome I)
- The Antecedents: (Outcomes I, II, III)
- Early 20th Century: (Outcomes I, II, III)
- The Jazz Age: (Outcomes I, II, III, VI)
- The Golden Age: (Outcomes I, II, III, IV, VI)
- Post-Golden Age: (Outcomes I, II, III, IV, VI)
- The New Millennium:
- Contemporary Musical Theatre: (Outcomes I, II, III, IV, VI)
- Practical Components: Hands-on activities, performance observations [in-person and online/video], and assignments. (Outcomes V, VI, VII, VIII)
- Analytical Tools: Critique guidelines, templates, and assessment tools like rubrics. (Outcome VIII).

Course Syllabus & Learning Outcomes

THE 2076 Course Description: Explores the evolution of musical theatre as a uniquely American theatrical artform. Provides an in-depth understanding of the changing sociopolitical contexts throughout the 19th, 20th, and 21st Centuries that directly influenced the trajectory of musical theatre in the American zeitgeist.

The content of this toolkit is adapted from *Backstage Pass: A Survey of American Musical Theatre* by Pamyla Stiehl and Bud Coleman, used with permission of the authors. No purchase of the book is required to use this toolkit.

Course Outcomes

- I. Identify key performers, directors, writers, producers, composers, etc. who have shaped the trajectory of American musical theatre.
- II. Understand the continually unfolding history of musical theatre beginning in the 19th Century through today, specifically, the representations of politics, race, class, gender, sexuality, religion, and ability excluded from and inherent in musicals.
- III. Analyze the six primary eras of musical theatre history
- IV. Critically examine the technical advancements born out of musical theatre
- V. Formulate and apply an argument about a musical's themes, composition, design, performance, and cultural impact
- VI. Create your own production concept based on elements taught throughout the semester

Toolkit Ingredients

Sample breakdown of a semester. Modify as needed.

Title/Week #	Week #	Description	Link
Course Syllabus & Learning Outcomes	1	State objectives and expectations.	Course Syllabus & Learning Outcomes
Introduction to Musical Theatre	1	Overview of key concepts, terms, musical theatre styles	Intro to Theatre
The Antecedents	2, 3	19th / early 20th century forms	The Antecedents
Early 20th Century	4, 5	Pioneers, birth of a genre	Early 20th Century
The Jazz Age	6, 7	America's Songbook	The Jazz Age
The Golden Age	8, 9	Musical theatre as we know it takes shape	The Golden Age
Post-Golden Age	10, 11	Revolutionizing musical theatre, Pop/Rock	Post-Golden Age
New Millennium	12, 13	Musicals of the 00's, and The Digital Age	The New Millennium
Contemporary Musical Theatre	14	Post-COVID, Short-form Vertical Media, Social Media	Contemporary Musical Theatre
Practical Assignments	15, 16	Putting what we learned into practice	Practical Assignments

Setting the Stage

Welcome to Broadway: The History of the American Musical

In this toolkit, you'll find information about the history of American musical theatre. It begins with a brief overview of key terms, musical theatre styles, and a breakdown of the musical format. From there, it moves through a comprehensive history of musical theatre beginning in the 19th Century and continuing through the 21st Century. Musical theatre, like all artforms, is shaped by sociopolitical and cultural contexts. The goings-on in the world directly impact how musical theatre transformed and grew into a uniquely American artform.

Musical theatre is as American as baseball, apple pie, and taxes. Audiences flocked to Broadway and regional theatres across the country to experience the extravagant sets, musical numbers, and stars that made this theatrical form what it is today. As musical theatre began to dominate the cultural zeitgeist in the 20's, over 200 productions were set to open on Broadway in [a single year!](#)

Throughout the course of the 20th Century, musical theatre became the defining American theatrical form. Composers like the Gershwins, Berlin, Rodgers/Hammerstein, Lerner/Lowe, Bernstein, Sondheim, Kander/Ebb, and Lloyd Webber, revolutionized storytelling through the musical medium. Directors and choreographers like de Mille, Abbott, Robbins, Fosse, and Bennett created some of the most recognizable shows that are continually reproduced and reimaged today. Stars like Waters, Baker, Merman, Lansbury, LuPone, Patinkin, and Peters embodied iconic characters that gripped audiences and cemented their legacies.

From the early extravaganzas like [Ziegfeld Follies](#) to the contemporary a cappella production of [In Transit](#), Broadway continues to be the place in which to push the boundaries of musical theatre. Musical theatre lives on as a form which can reflect the American experience back onto audiences; the good, bad, and ugly. American musical theatre has always served as a mirror to society and has been both a space in which marginalized groups have been excluded as well as celebrated. Understanding the historical context in order to appreciate how far musical theatre has come is the purpose of the course.

Intro to Theatre

Understanding key terms and musical styles will provide useful context when moving through the 6 historical eras of musical theatre. Below are concepts and terms to help with distinguishing musical theatre from other performance forms.

Foundational Concepts

The Golden Triangle

Represents a model in which three elements, music, words, and action, fuse to create the basis for musical theatre performance.

Bubble Formula

The idea that, in musical theatre, when words can no longer express and contain heightened emotion; the body sings, and when song becomes insufficient, the body dances. Dialogue → Song → Dance.

Key Vocabulary

- Composer: the person who writes the music
- Choreography: the dance steps or movement on stage created by the choreographer
- Libretto (book): the story, characters, script, written by the librettist
- Lyrics: the words to the songs, written by the lyricist
- Score: the music and lyrics (written by the composer)

Types of Musicals

Book Musical

Traditional musical form in which the libretto is integrated with song and dance to tell a linear narrative. Popular in “The Golden Age” examples include *Wicked*, *Chicago*, *My Fair Lady*, *West Side Story*.

Rock, Pop/Rock Musical

Modern musical built upon a contemporary music aesthetic like hip hop, rock, and pop. Themes often include counterculture, youth rebellion, alienation, etc. Examples include *Hair*, *RENT*, *Spring Awakening*, *Jagged Little Pill*, *American Idiot*, *Hamilton*.

Concept Musical

Modern musicals in which the theme or idea is more important than plot; songs and dances are connected by a theme to convey an idea instead of relaying a linear story. Sondheim’s musicals are a prime example of this.

Sung-Through Musical

Modern musical form which resembles an opera by being mostly sung and underscored with little spoken dialogue. Examples include works by Boublil and Schönberg and Andrew Lloyd Webber.

Jukebox Musical

A musical consisting of a series of pre-written songs (typically popular hits) connected into a loose storyline. Can be from one or multiple composers, including pop artists and music groups. Examples include: Mamma Mia!, Jersey Boys, Rock of Ages, & Juliet, The Cher Musical.

Dance Musical

A musical that is almost entirely danced, with little or no spoken dialogue and often a jukebox score. Examples include: Fosse, Contact, Movin' Out, and Come Fly Away.

Reflexive Musical

A post-Modern category of self-referential musicals that celebrate and/or poke fun at their own musical identity. Examples include: Urinetown, The Producers, Monty Python's Spamalot, Rock of Ages, Death Becomes Her.

Screen-to-Stage Musical

A musical using the book and some/all of the score of an existing film. Examples include: Disney's Beauty and The Beast, The Color Purple, Billy Elliot, Mary Poppins, Shrek the Musical, Sister Act, Newsies, Once, Hairspray. Disney has especially dominated this category.

The Antecedents

Although musical theatre is a uniquely American invention, its roots extend all the way back to the 18th Century and even across the Atlantic back to Europe. Two of the most famous "pre-musical theatre" artists were William Gilbert and Arthur Sullivan of Gilbert & Sullivan fame! Their work in bringing light opera to stages across the United Kingdom and beyond helped inspire the theatrical performances underway in the United States at the end of the 19th Century.

Minstrelsy

Like most American artforms, musical theatre has a checkered history. Originally, the bulk of live musical performances in the US were being performed as Minstrelsy/minstrel shows. These were Blackface performances that date back to the late 1700s and continued all the way

through to the early 20th Century. Unfortunately, there are still Blackface performances occurring today (such as the film *Tropic Thunder*).

To help understand this, here are some key facts about minstrelsy:

- 1828: Thomas D. Rice creates “Jim Crow” character
- 1843: The Virginia Minstrels, a blackface group, form in NYC
- 1846: The Christy Minstrels form in NYC and introduce key minstrelsy characters like the Interlocutor, etc.
- These shows depict derogatory and racist stereotypes of Southern slaves
 - Also derided immigrants, women, and other marginalized groups
- This form was extremely popular in the US from 1850-1870
 - Performed by and for white, male audiences
- The Minstrel Show also had a specific structure to it:
 - Part 1: Preamble – walk-around/cakewalk
 - Part 2: Mr. Interlocutor and Endmen (Mr. Tambo and Bones)
 - Part 3: “Olio” (variety acts)
 - Part 4: “Afterpiece” – one-act play or sketch show
 - Part 5: Celebratory dance

A recent musical that depicts the minstrel show structure as well as other elements of it is Kander and Ebb’s [The Scottsboro Boys \(2010\)](#).

After the Civil War, African American performers began to form their own minstrel groups, thus reclaiming the performance form.

- 1865: Booker and Clayton’s Georgia Minstrels was the first popular African American blackface minstrel troupe
- 1891: The Creole Show: All-Black cast and first female interlocutor
- 1898: *Clorindy, or the Origin of the Cakewalk*: a one-act musical and the first Broadway musical with an all-Black cast
- The legacy of the Minstrel Show is one full of racist and bigoted views while also introducing some popular musical forms like: Gospel, The Blues, Tap dancing, and the two-performer comedy routine

Other 19th-Century Forms

Other forms that emerged in the 19th Century that inspired musical theatre were:

Burlesque

Satirical, musical productions. Oftentimes spoofed famous works like Shakespeare and engaged in social commentary.

- 1868: Lydia Thompson and “British Blondes” bring burlesque to America
- Parodies, variety acts, drag, improv, risqué costumes,

Extravaganza

Similar to burlesque but with less satire and more spectacle

- Contained a variety of different performances similar to burlesque

Vaudeville

Series of unrelated acts (variety show).

Has its origins in New York City's Bowery saloons, known for being "immigrant entertainment"

Black Vaudeville

T.O.B.A. (Theatre Owners Booking Association) circuit formed in the 1910s specifically for Black performers and audiences.

- Performers like Josephine Baker, Ma Rainey, Bessie Smith, and Louis Armstrong got their start on this circuit

Early 20th Century

In the late 1890's, Oscar Hammerstein bought a plot of land between 43rd and 45th Streets in New York City and began building theaters. [Broadway as we know it was no more than a simple street at this time.](#) but Hammerstein's presence supercharged this area of Midtown Manhattan. [In 1904, the NYC Subway opened for operation](#) which helped bring much needed foot traffic and business to this area of town. By 1910, 34 theaters were established and running in and around Midtown. In addition to Hammerstein I, there were other influential figures helping shape the early days of Broadway.

- **Florenz Ziegfeld Jr. (1867-1932):** along with his wife, Anna Held, created the Ziegfeld Follies in 1907. An annual extravaganza that he produced until 1931. "The Ziegfeld Girls" were the first chorus dancers on Broadway and are direct inspirations for The Rockettes.
- **George M. Cohan (1878-1942):** dubbed "the man who owned Broadway," Cohan wrote, composed, produced, and appeared in over 3 dozen Broadway shows. Helped develop the "book musical" through his advancement of plot in the libretto and score.
 - Cohan was also an instrumental part of Tin Pan Alley

In addition to Broadway, ["Showboats"](#) were seeing a boom in popularity. These were floating theaters that sailed along the Ohio and Mississippi Rivers. Highly popular from 1831-1940s. Mainly featured minstrel shows, vaudeville, and melodramas. They also inspired the 1927 breakout musical "Showboat" by Jerome Kern.

- **Jerome Kern (1885-1945):** dubbed "The Father of American Musical Theatre" proved that musicals could be more than comedies, they could address highly prevalent social themes.

- Some of his innovations include:
 - Overture: the music before the show begins
 - Reprise: A repeat of an earlier song, sometimes in a different format
 - AABA song format: song formula in which the chorus is organized into 3 repeated melodic refrains
 - Leitmotifs: short refrains provided as part of the underscoring and specifically associated with a character or certain dramatic action ([A character's theme song!](#))
- Major productions: Eddie, Oh, Boy!, Sunny, Show Boat

The Jazz Age

From roughly 1920-1940, this era of musical theatre (and music in America more broadly) serves as a musical and entertainment revolution. The entire popular music industry becomes integrated into Broadway, Hollywood, and Tin Pan Alley.

[Tin Pan Alley](#) was located specifically on West 28th Street between Broadway Ave. and 6th Ave. It was the hot spot for composers, lyricists, and songwriters to churn out popular hits that would spread across the country. Many musical theatre artists came in and out of this highly creative block in NYC. The role of the “song plugger” is formed as well.

Some musical forms born from Tin Pan Alley include:

- Waltzes
- Sentimental ballads
- Songs written to be performed in blackface by white performers
- Ragtime
- Novelty songs like “take me out to the ball game”

One of the most famous musical forms emerges from this time: [syncopation](#), which is a rhythm that is played off of the main beats, or “off beat.” Ragtime music is all about syncopation and would eventually help inspire the Broadway musical [of the same name](#).

With new musical styles also come new forms of dance: The Charleston, and the Varsity Drag become extremely popular during this time. These forms will also eventually make their way onto Broadway stages.

During this period, [the Harlem Renaissance](#) greatly influenced arts and culture in New York City and around the country. It began the slow process of changing bigoted views toward the African American community. Although, there were frequent tensions between the predominantly Black performances occurring in Harlem and the predominantly white shows produced on Broadway.

- 1920s-30s: height of the Harlem Renaissance
 - Ushered in a new wave of African American culture, fashion, literature, politics, art, music, and more

- 1917: a series of plays rejecting blackface and minstrelsy were produced in Harlem
- Popular figures from the time: Langston Hughes (writer), W.E.B. Dubois (writer), Marcus Garvey (political activist), Duke Ellington (musician), Ethel Waters (musician), Josephine Baker (performer and fashion icon).

Important musical theatre figures from the era:

Irving Berlin (1888-1989)

A remarkably prolific songwriter, composed 899 songs with 451 hits. Worked on *Annie Get Your Gun*, as well as the song “White Christmas”

- Major productions: *Annie Get Your Gun*, *Face the Music*, *As Thousands Cheer*

George Gershwin (1898-1937)

Emerged out of Tin Pan Alley, wrote the modern masterpiece “Rhapsody in Blue” and worked with his brother to create classics like *Porgy and Bess*, *Lady Be Good!* And more. An early example of mixing musical styles like classical with jazz and the blues. Helps integrate jazz into Broadway.

- Major productions: *Of Thee I Sing*, *Porgy and Bess*, *Lady Be Good!*, *Strike Up the Band*, *Let ‘Em Eat Cake*

Ira Gershwin (1896-1983)

Did not have quite the career his brother had and took longer for his career to take off. However, he co-wrote the lyrics for *Porgy and Bess* and moved to Hollywood with George to work on film scores. Some musical hits include, “I Got Rhythm,” “S’Wonderful,” “They Can’t Take That Away From Me,” “Embraceable You”

- Major productions: *Of Thee I Sing*, *Porgy and Bess*, *Strike Up the Band*, *Let ‘Em Eat Cake*

Cole Porter (1891-1964)

Wrote over 800 songs and musicals including, *Anything Goes*, and *Kiss Me, Kate*. Won several Tony Awards

- Major productions: *Anything Goes*, *Kiss Me Kate*

The Golden Age

The Golden Age era is argued to have lasted roughly from 1943–1964. Scholars say it is bookended by the musicals *Oklahoma!* and *Fiddler on the Roof*. Many elements of musical theatre help define this prolific era in musical theatre history including the expansion of the libretto and a stronger focus on choreography. In addition, the director and choreographer are both now seen as integral to a successful musical (not so much leading up to this era).

While all art reflects the era from which it emerges, the Golden Age of musical theatre sees a specific focus on musicals about the American identity including themes more explicitly about race, gender, sexuality, youth culture, and corporatism. Naturally, the post-WWII period has an extremely important influence on musical theatre. The theatre becomes a place of refuge and, especially, entertainment. But Broadway does not solely focus on American identities, it also welcomes stories about international identities and struggles (Rodgers and Hammerstein have a huge influence in this area). Female characters become important figures of strength and self-determination and musical theatre begins to expand the concept of gender roles. It is also in this era that the industry's biggest award ceremony is introduced: the Tony Awards (1947).

Important musical theatre figures from the era:

Oscar Hammerstein II (1895-1960)

Son of Hammerstein I, creator of the theatre district. Massively influential as a lyricist, worked on 11 musicals with Richard Rodgers. R&H became famous for writing a vast array of stories that both dealt with the American experience as well as international stories.

- Some of his innovations include:
 - Quasi Love Songs: romance suggested rather than blatantly announced
 - Self-contained song/scene: action/resolution of a scene in song format
 - [Song-as-soliloquy](#): one character singing their thoughts aloud
 - Metatheater: a show within a show. (This has been around for centuries but Hammerstein was one of the first to really integrate it into musical theatre)
- Major productions: Oklahoma!, The King and I, Cinderella, The Sound of Music, Show Boat, Flower Drum Song, Green Grow the Lilacs

Richard Rodgers (1902-1979)

Born into a musical, Jewish family. Jerome Kern had a huge influence on him as a composer. Primary collaborators were first, Hart and then, Hammerstein II.

- Along with Hart, the first writing duo to be nicknamed a “team.” They focused more on stand-alone songs within a musical than creating a cohesive show.
- Major productions: Oklahoma!, The Sound of Music, Cinderella, Flower Drum Song, The King and I, Pal Joey

Lorenz Hart (1895-1943)

Hart's lyrics were highly personal and presented love in carnal, cynical, and satirical manners (something that would go on to help define the Golden Age). a “self-expressive” lyricist, writing from his own lived experience.

- His relationship with Rodgers ended on a sour note when Hart showed up drunk to the opening night of their final project together, A Connecticut Yankee.

- Major productions: Pal Joey, On Your Toes, Babes in Arms, A Connecticut Yankee

Ethel Waters (1896-1977)

Birth records vary. Waters began singing in local nightclubs at 17 and worked the Chitlin Circuit, which was a series of segregated venues that featured Black performers.

- 1920: moves to Harlem and contributes her talents to the Harlem Renaissance, famously distrusted “white theatre” on Broadway and beyond.
- 1927: Makes Broadway debut in *Africana*
- 1933: Goes to Berlin to star in *As Thousands Cheer*. The only Black actor and delivers a famously heart-wrenching performance. Continued a long career on [Broadway](#) and [Hollywood](#).

George Abbott (1887-1995): Had a remarkably long and successful career on Broadway.

Trained as an actor in his early years but loved to write and would go on to direct and produce as well. Was involved with over 100 shows throughout his 70-year career, including:

- 1913: first Broadway show as a performer
- 1925: first Broadway show as a playwright
- 1926: first Broadway show as a director
- 1930s: begins producing shows on Broadway
- Major productions: Pal Joey, On the Town, Call Me Madam, [The Pajama Game](#), *Damn Yankees*, *Once Upon a Mattress*, *A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum*, etc.

Jerome Robbins (1918-1998): started his career with the Yiddish Art Theatre and became a member of the Ballet Theatre (with Agnes deMille)

- Helps solidify the Golden Triangle concept by reemphasizing the role of dance in musical theatre
- The first director/choreographer combo (inspiring many, many more to follow)
- Major productions: *The King and I*, *The Pajama Game*, *Fiddler on the Roof*, *West Side Story*, *Gypsy*, *On the Town*

Agnes de Mille (1905-1993): born to a prosperous show business family (uncle was Cecil B. DeMille). Helped popularize “character dances” which were combinations of pantomime and formal dance. Helps build the American Ballet Theatre with Robbins.

- Collaborated with Rodgers & Hammerstein (*Oklahoma!*, *Carousel*), Lerner & Loewe (*Brigadoon*, *Allegro*).
- Another important director/choreographer combo and helped position choreography as integral to the musical process

Dorothy Fields (1904-1974): the “Woman Songwriter” made her start in Tin Pan Alley and eventually moved to Hollywood. First female to win an Oscar and a Tony award and entered into the Songwriters Hall of Fame.

- Co-wrote over 400 songs, 15 musicals, 26 films including the book for *Annie Get Your Gun*
- Wrote songs for Black performers during the Harlem Renaissance

Alan Jay Lerner (1918-1986): met his future creative partner (Loewe) at a NYC-based social club when he wrote the lyrics for a variety show

- Hugely influential during the Golden Age, wrote more lighthearted shows with social themes. Unintentionally wrote the first concept musical *Love Life* with Kurt Weill after his success with Loewe.
- Major productions: *My Fair Lady*, *Brigadoon*, *Camelot*, *Paint Your Wagon*, *On a Clear Day You Can See Forever*

Frederick Loewe (1904-1988): born in Berlin, considered a musical prodigy by age 7, immigrated to the US in 1924. Did not initially see success for the first decade in NYC, played for nightclubs and variety acts. Saw failed partnerships before meeting Lerner at the Lambs Club and striking up a creative partnership.

- *My Fair Lady* was the most successful Broadway show since *Oklahoma!* And solidified Lerner and Loewe as Broadway icons.
- Major productions: *My Fair Lady*, *Brigadoon*, *Camelot*, *Paint Your Wagon*

The middle of the 20th Century saw a huge shift in American culture. During WWII men were off at war and women had a crucial and indispensable role in the workforce, helping drive the US war machine. During this time, gay culture thrived albeit underground. There were gay and lesbian bars all across the country and a more open culture seemed to be emerging. However, in the post-WWII period, the men returned to an economic boom, and there was a renewed fight against Communism which ushered in a distinctly sharp turn away from a more progressive social society. Suddenly, being gay was equated with Communism and women were forced back into the home. This gave rise to The Pygmalion Myth.

- The Pygmalion Myth: is the idea that a woman can be molded into a male-dominated ideal. She cannot reach her full potential without the intervention of a man.
- This concept is explored in Lerner and Loewe's *My Fair Lady* and is seen in a variety of other musicals like *Oklahoma!*, *Kiss Me, Kate*, *The Sound of Music*, *Gypsy*, *Funny Girl*, as well as post-Golden Age musicals like *Grease*, *Hairspray*, *42nd Street*, *Legally Blonde*, and most fairytales.
- There is no question that this myth is a defining feature of the Golden Age.
- Audre Lorde (1934-1992): although not a musical theatre artist, Lorde's writing on key sociocultural issues helped define this period.
 - Wrote extensively about issues of gender, sexuality, race, feminism, binaries, and more. Coined the term "Afro-German" due to her extensive time spent in Berlin, and helped popularize the term "intersectionality"
 - A contributor to third-wave feminism and disagreed with notable white feminists.
 - 1984 seminal essay "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House"
- Jule Styne (1905-1994): most produced composer of original musicals during the Golden Age. From 1949-1974, a musical with a Styne-score premiered each season on Broadway in show business more broadly. An EGOT winner.
 - Star vehicle: a show written or produced with a singular performer in mind.

- Some Styne stars include: Carol Channing, Mary Martin, Ethel Merman, Barbra Streisand, and Carol Burnett
 - Major productions: Gypsy, Funny Girl, Peter Pan, The Pajama Game, Gentlemen Prefer Blondes
- Ethel Merman (1908-1984): known as “the undisputed First Lady of the musical comedy stage” who cemented her legacy as a Broadway icon. Performed in *Girl Crazy* (1930) her first Broadway show. Starred in 5 Cole Porter musicals, including the star-turning role of Reno Sweeney in *Anything Goes*. Also starred in *Annie Get Your Gun* which ran for 3 years (Merman only missed two performances during the whole run!). Was the inspiration for *Hello, Dolly!* But she didn’t join the cast until 6 years into the run.
 - Major productions: *Annie Get Your Gun*, *Girl Crazy*, *Hello, Dolly!*, *Gypsy*, *Call Me Madam* (Tony Award)

Hooking the Audience

This is a way to keep the audience’s attention both at the top of the show and after intermission. This performance technique is not unique to the Golden Age but there are concepts that became highly popular during this time, such as the star vehicle. It is important to know the various ways of hooking an audience when analyzing musicals and understanding musical progression throughout the 20th Century.

1. Star vehicle: As mentioned above, this is a show designed to showcase the talents of a particular star. The show typically requires a lot of energy from the performer, asking them to “carry” the show. From an economic perspective: the star can also bring along a built-in fanbase (this is especially apparent if actors also star in TV/film. I.e. Sara Ramirez from *Grey’s Anatomy* who starred in *Monty Python’s Spamalot* on Broadway)
 - a. Popular shows as star vehicles: *Hello, Dolly!*, *Fiddler on the Roof*, *Mame*, *Evita*, *Sunset Boulevard*, *Phantom of the Opera*, *Chicago*, *La Cage aux Folles*, *Sweeney Todd*, *Wicked*, *Hamilton*, *Hadestown*
2. The “I Am / I Want song”: this is when a character tells the audience who they are, what they want, and why the audience should care. This is often an introductory number early in the show and provides an opportunity to display the performer’s virtuosity.
 - a. “I Can’t Say No” – *Ado Annie*, *Oklahoma!*
 - b. “I Feel Pretty” – *Maria*, *West Side Story*
 - c. “Some People” – *Mama Rose*, *Gypsy*
 - d. “If I Were a Rich Man” – *Tevye*, *Fiddler on the Roof*
 - e. “Worst Pies in London” – *Mrs. Lovett*, *Sweeney Todd*
 - f. “The King of Broadway” – *Max Bialystock*, *The Producers*
 - g. “The Schuyler Sisters” – *Angelica*, *Eliza*, *Peggy*, *Hamilton*
 - h. And many, many more
3. Show Opener / Grabber: as the title suggests, this is the first number in the musical (can sometimes be an “I Am / I Want” song as well, i. e. “Tradition” from *Fiddler on the Roof*). Prior to the 1940s, musicals typically began with large production numbers in order to keep the audience’s attention, although, without much plot. The Golden Age transformed

this to introduce the plot very quickly. It also sets the stage, provides exposition, and introduces the main players. Not to mention, infuse a ton of energy!

- a. "Wilkommen" – Cabaret
 - b. "Rent" – RENT
 - c. "Circle of Life" – The Lion King
 - d. "In the Heights" – In the Heights
 - e. "Hello!" – The Book of Mormon
 - f. "Ragtime" – Ragtime
4. Intermission Teaser: A powerhouse number which leaves the audience on the edge of their seats and wanting more right before intermission. Ranges from being a confessional moment of crisis to a musicalized pivot point for a single character to a celebratory or rallying production number that invigorates the musical. A cliff hanger! This keeps the audience humming the number as they go to the bathroom or buy merchandise and demands they stay for Act II.
- a. "Everything's Coming Up Roses" – Gypsy
 - b. "Don't Rain on My Parade" – Funny Girl
 - c. "A Little Priest" – Sweeney Todd
 - d. "Defying Gravity" – Wicked
 - e. "La Vie Boheme" – RENT
 - f. "Voulez-Vous" – Mamma Mia
5. The 11:00 Number: Re-engages the audience by closing the production on a dramatic high note. Acquired the nickname because it occurs toward the end of a 3-hour production if the show time starts at 8pm, making the song happen around 11pm. It is an original song (not a reprise) sung by the lead performer. There is always an 11:00 number in a star vehicle production. It is often a showstopper and can even garner a standing ovation before the show is over, depending on the star. Provides a moment of truth/recognition/insight/discovery for the leading character. Important: it is not always a singular character, it can often be a full cast moment.
- a. "Rose's Turn" – Gypsy
 - b. "Being Alive" – Company
 - c. "Cabaret" – Cabaret
 - d. "You Can't Stop the Beat" – Hairspray
 - e. "One" – A Chorus Line
 - f. "Freak Flag" – Shrek: The Musical
 - g. "Springtime for Hitler" – The Producers

Jewish Influence in Musical Theatre

By 1910, nearly a quarter of the New York City population identified as Jewish. Seeing as Broadway was the epicenter for musical theatre, this also meant that Jewish people had a significant influence on the artform. Indeed, many Jewish neighborhoods in NYC were sites of intense creative generation, such as Tin Pan Alley. This also meant that there was a distinct Yiddish theatre as well as English-speaking theater emerging throughout NYC. Although the Jewish identity was pronounced among musical theatre creatives, many sought to change their

names to sound “less-Jewish” for fear of persecution. Due to shared struggles and persecution (especially during WWII), Jewish presence in musical theatre also led to an increased presence and acceptance of African Americans on Broadway and beyond.

- Major Jewish musical theatre figures include: Fanny Brice, Eddie Cantor, Anna Held, Al Jolson, the Marx Brothers, the Gershwins, Irving Berlin, Oscar Hammerstein II, Richard Rodgers, Lorenz Hart, Jerome Kern, Jerome Robbins, Stephen Sondheim, Leonard Bernstein, Frederick Loewe, Zero Mostel, Sheldon Harnick, Jerry Bock, Joseph Stein, Jule Styne and many, many more.

As the Golden Age neared its end, Broadway continued to see an increase in productions season after season. The economic boom in the United States after WWII had people flocking to the theatre in order to see the newest hit and forget the dark days of the war. West Side Story opened in 1957 and, although the production only ran for 732 performances, it provided inspiration for the film which garnered 10 Oscar nominations and 9 wins. To give perspective, it was nominated for the Tony Award for Best Musical but lost to The Music Man, a stark difference in tone and story and what audiences wanted to see. But the legacy of WSS continues to this day. It introduced the concept of triple threat performers, those who could sing, act, and dance exceptionally well. It is also important to note that although WSS was predominantly about Puerto Rican immigrants, the show was created by 4 Jewish men. This fact continues to complicate the legacy of the production.

In addition, WSS helped launch the careers of two monumentally influential musical theatre figures:

- Leonard Bernstein (1918-1990): a celebrated symphony conductor and composer. He eventually crossed-over into musical theatre (similarly to George Gershwin). Bernstein’s training as a classical musician brought a complexity to his musical theatre compositions and musical theatre more broadly.
 - Through his Young People’s Concerts, Bernstein elevated the position of “conductor” to a fame status and helped teach music to kids across the country.
 - Although married to a Chilean performer named Felicia Cohn Montealegre, it was a well-known fact that Bernstein carried on relationships with men.
 - Collaborated with Robbins, Sondheim, Lerner, Comden, Green, and more.
 - Major productions: On the Town, Wonderful Town, Candide, West Side Story
- Stephen Sondheim (1930-2021) [link to slideshow](#): without question, the most important, prolific, and celebrated composer/lyricist of American Musical Theatre. Sondheim can and should receive his own entire unit in any musical theatre history course Throughout his varied career, Sondheim wrote musicals with the following subject matter (in no particular order): Georges Seurat, Plautus, Ziegfeld Follies, foreign films, Kabuki, cannibalism, imperialism, urban alienation, presidential assassins, defective relationships, fluid time continuums, obsessive passions, and the American Dream. He viewed musical theatre as both an artform and a problem to solve, leading to iconic musicals and utter flops. His genius is unmatched by any other musical theatre composer or lyricist. And his career is as diverse as his shows. Here are some brief highlights of his life and career:

- Mentored by Oscar Hammerstein II. Fell in love with musical theatre after seeing Hammerstein's *Very Warm for May* (1939). Ended up working for both R&H on their Broadway show *Allegro*. Hammerstein was extremely hard on Sondheim, which he loved.
- By age 16, he had written his first show *By George!*
- *West Side Story* was his first Broadway show, Arthur Laurents helped him secure the gig as lyricist
- First Broadway show as both composer/lyricist: *A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum* (1962) was his biggest Broadway hit (still to this date) running for 964 performances.
- Popularized the concept musical with the opening of *Company*, his first of many collaborations with director Harold Prince and librettist George Furth. Michael Bennett served as the choreographer and the show ended up winning 6 Tony Awards
- To date his biggest flop is *Anyone Can Whistle* (1964), running only 9 performances.
- Indicators of a Sondheim song include: extensive word play, cleverness, alliteration, rhyme, along with highly complex musical compositions
 - One of the most complex and witty songs in musical theatre history is the Act 1 finale of *Sweeney Todd*, titled "[A Little Priest](#)"
- Created 19 musicals (16 of which he solely wrote the music and lyrics)
- There are several revues of music from his shows:
 - *Side by Side* by Sondheim
 - *Putting it Together*
 - *Mostly Sondheim*
 - *Sondheim on Sondheim*
- There is much more to be said on this giant of musical theatre but, for now, here is a list of his major awards:
 - 8 Tony Awards (more than any other composer)
 - Pulitzer Prize for *Sunday in the Park with George*
 - 1 Academy Award
 - 8 Grammy Awards
 - Kennedy Center Honors
 - Congressional Medal of Freedom
 - The Stephen Sondheim Theatre on Broadway
- Similar to Jule Styne, there is an array of actors who consistently perform in his shows including: Bernadette Peters, Patti LuPone, Imelda Staunton, Angela Lansbury, Mandy Patinkin, Raul Esparza, Elaine Stritch, Christine Baranski, Audra McDonald.
- This [tribute](#) to Sondheim after his death puts his legacy into perspective
- Harold "Hal" Prince (1928-2019): a hugely influential Broadway producer and director. Most of the composers/lyricists/choreographers from this time worked with Prince on one show or another including Fosse, Robbins, Bennett, Stroman, Bernstein, Kander/Ebb,

Lloyd Webber, etc. He helped develop the “concept musical” through his many partnerships with Sondheim. Viewed his art as political.

- Major productions: West Side Story, Damn Yankees, Fiddler on the Roof, Cabaret, A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum, Cabaret, Sweeney Todd, Evita, Phantom of the Opera, Candide, Parade, Kiss of the Spider-Woman

The bookend to the Golden Age is said to be the Broadway smash hit, Fiddler on the Roof (1964). Its themes on Jewish identity, family, tradition, and persecution resonated deeply with audiences and cemented its position as a triumphant success on Broadway. In fact, it was the first musical to run over 3000 performances! It received 9 Tony Awards including Best Musical Score, Book, Direction, Choreography, and Leading Actor/Actress. Many of the songs made their way into pop culture, like “If I Were A Rich Man.” Interestingly, Jerry Bock and Sheldon Harnick, the creators of the show, stayed mostly out of the spotlight and diverted all attention to their art. [Link to slideshow](#)

Influential musical theatre figures from the era:

- Sheldon Harnick (1924-2023): served in WWII and wrote/performed original songs for USO shows but struggled to find work immediately after the war. Finally caught a break when one of his songs was added to a Broadway review in 1952. Worked closely with Jerry Bock and Joseph Stein but eventually parted ways and collaborated a bit with Rodgers.
 - Major productions: Fiorello!, She Loves Me, The Rothschilds, Fiddler on the Roof
- Jerry Bock (1928-2010): gifted pianist and wrote songs in high school for touring productions. Started writing for television revues in NYC as well as for summer resorts in Upstate NY. Co-wrote the score for Mr. Wonderful which was a star vehicle for Sammy Davis Jr.
 - Major productions: Fiorello!, She Loves Me, The Rothschilds, Fiddler on the Roof, Mr. Wonderful
- Joseph Stein (1912-2010): originally had a career in TV writing for Jackie Gleason, Mel Brooks, Neil Simon, Sid Caesar, and Carl Reiner. Had a 1948 Broadway debut with the revue, Lend Me an Ear. Had huge success with Fiddler but lost some notoriety afterwards, most of his librettos are now popular Off-Broadway, in regional theatres, and on the West End. Was highly collaborative and worked with a variety of composers/lyricists, including Kander/Ebb, Harnick/Bock, and Stephen Schwartz.
 - Major productions: Fiddler on the Roof, Lend Me an Ear, Enter Laughing, The Baker's Wife
- Zero Mostel (1915-1977): born in NYC and immediately found a passion for performing and comedy. Worked as an actor in Yiddish theatre. Although his only two musicals were A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum and Fiddler on the Roof (winning a Tony for both), he had a long career on Broadway, TV, and film, which solidified him as an iconic performer. He was notorious for ad-libbing and ignoring direction
 - Mostel was blacklisted by the House Un-American Activities Committee for his purported association with the Communist Party and refusing to give up names of

other artists during the Red Scare. In addition to Mostel, Jerome Robbins was also subpoena'd by HUAC where he voluntarily gave up names whereas Mostel refused. This led to high tensions during *Fiddler* when the two were working together. Although they did not like each other, they put their differences aside and created an extremely memorable production.

Post-Golden Age

It is fitting that the Golden Age should, in effect, end in 1964 with the opening of *Fiddler* on the Roof. The tumultuous events of the 1960s produce art that responds to this upheaval of American culture and politics.

This brief list of events will help put the state of the country into perspective:

Civil Rights Movement

- Freedom Rides and sit-ins (1961)
- March on Washington (1963)
- National Organization for Women (NOW) and second-wave feminism (around 1966)
- Assassinations of JFK (1963), MLK Jr. (1968), RFK (1968)
- Stonewall Riots (June 1969)
- Moon Landing (July 1969)
- Woodstock (August 1969)
- Escalation of the Vietnam War throughout the 60s.

All of these major events not only shaped American society but, naturally, musical theatre as well. One of the shows in which this was most apparent was the tribal love-rock musical *Hair* which opened on Broadway in 1968.

- *Hair* was created by Gerome Ragni, James Rado, and Galt MacDermot. The show contained themes of anti-war, anti-establishment, pro-drugs, pro-sex, humanist and tribal sentiments. Both Ragni and Rado were products of the counterculture of the 60's (and were life partners)
- Several songs became pop hits, such as: "Aquarius" "Let the Sunshine In" ["Hair"](#)
- Important: helped introduce Rock/Pop music to Broadway!
- The show was initially produced through Joseph Papp's new concept for NYC theatre: Off-Broadway
 - Off-Broadway: started in the 50's but gained popularity in the 60's. It describes a group of small Manhattan theaters (100-499 seats) which provided experimental theatre offerings for select audiences
 - The "Broadway Box" refers to theaters located between 40th and 54th streets and at this time, "Off-Broadway" refers to those theaters.
 - These theaters also had more flexibility in terms of the content they could offer and were not beholden to actor unions.

- Popular shows that started Off-Broadway: The Threepenny Opera, The Fantasticks, Hair, Little Shop of Horrors, Hamilton, Heathers, Hadda Hottel

The 1960s also produced the legendary creative team of John Kander and Fred Ebb, known simply as Kander and Ebb. They wrote some of the most influential, innovative, and audacious concept musicals of the post-Golden Age period. Their collaboration was close, long-standing, and resulted in 17 musicals as well as numerous scores/songs for TV and film. Similarly to Jule Styne, they wrote music with specific voices in mind, such as Barbra Streisand and Liza Minnelli.

- John Kander (born 1927): born in Missouri and didn't move to NYC until his 20's (despite having a cosmopolitan, urban feel to his music). One of his first NYC gigs was as a rehearsal pianist for West Side Story and as accompanist for Gypsy auditions. Jerome Robbins and Harold Prince invigorated his career.
- Fred Ebb (1928-2004): born in NYC and worked odd jobs. Had a collaborative partnership with Paul Klein with whom he wrote a number of songs for the nightclub scene in NYC. Continued writing for theatrical revues and worked with a variety of people, including Jerry Herman, before meeting Kander.
 - Both Kander and Ebb had a unique ability to write songs that sounded authentic to the context of their play. For example, "Tomorrow Belongs to Me" in the musical Cabaret was often confused for a traditional German folk song.
 - Their musicals spanned themes and locations and often dealt with deep, dark issues with a unique jazz flare.
 - Major productions: Cabaret, Chicago, Kiss of the Spider Woman, And the World Goes 'Round, Woman of the Year, The Visit, The Scottsboro Boys
 - Notable partnerships: Liza Minnelli, Barbra Streisand, Chita Rivera, Gwen Verdon, Lauren Bacall, Kristin Chenoweth, Martin Scorsese, Bob Fosse, Hal Prince, Rob Marshall, Bob Fosse, Susan Stroman, and Terrence McNally.
- Bob Fosse (1927-1987): born in Chicago and started dancing at the age of 9. Worked in the entertainment division of the Navy. A hugely influential director/choreographer whose influence is seen throughout Broadway and show business.
 - Popularized the self-reflexive choreographer: where the dance calls attention to the performer/choreographer through unique movements rather than serving the plot or story (somewhat opposite of de Mille and Robbins)
 - Mentored by Robbins during The Pajama Game
 - Utilized hats, gloves, feathers, and other props throughout his choreography
 - Choreographed 12 Broadway musicals and directing 7
 - Won 9 Tony Awards
 - Major productions: The Pajama Game, [Damn Yankees](#), How to Succeed in Business Without Really Trying, Sweet Charity, Pippin, Chicago, Cabaret

Several of their shows also contain a metatheatrical element to them.

- Metatheatrical: shows that illustrate and celebrate the world of theatre, might contain: rehearsal segments, audition scenes, or a show-within-a-show

- Examples: Show Boat, Annie Get Your Gun, Cabaret, A Chorus Line, The Producers,
- Conceptually metaphoric: when a work emphasizes the idea that everything is a performance. Entire worlds are built through metatheatrical numbers
 - Examples: Cabaret, Hair, Chicago, Pippin, Dreamgirls, The Drowsy Chaperone
- Alienation effect: wherein the theatrical elements are laid bare for the audience to see. This was employed throughout Kander/Ebb works and regularly in the theatre. This term was popularized by Bertolt Brecht, who believed the theatre should inspire audiences to take action rather than “suspend their disbelief.”

Following in the footsteps of Hair, Broadway musicals take a decisively more rock/pop turn in the 70s, 80s, and 90s. Perhaps unsurprisingly, musical theatre continues to be highly influenced by the popular music of the zeitgeist. If The Jazz Age was inspired by jazz, the blues, and gospel, then it stands to reason musical theatre in the latter half of the 20th Century would be inspired by disco, glam rock, boy bands, etc. This next era in musical theatre will focus on the themes in pop/rock musicals as well as the major players in the industry.

Themes in Pop/Rock musicals include:

- Youth culture: shows that deal with coming-of-age issues and stories
 - Typically involves a younger cast of performers (i.e. Spring Awakening)
 - Employs cutting edge technology, especially lights and sound
- Counterculture: looks at stories where the characters are alienated from society
 - Characters are bound to each other through lifestyle choices, misfit status, detachment from society (i.e. RENT)
- Rebellion in search of identity: characters who test the boundaries as they figure out who they are (i.e. Dreamgirls)
 - Often highlights identity such as race, ethnicity, sexuality, and gender
 - Pop/Rock musicals often blur the binaries of categorization and can come in the form of jukebox musicals, sung-through musicals, and megamusicals (a new kind of musical which emerged from this era)
- Michael Bennett (1943-1987): another example of a hugely influential director/choreographer combination. Bennett’s rise on Broadway. He created dance-centric musicals and incorporated moving sets to highlight his complex choreography. One of the most famous examples of this is the number “The Mirror and Me” from A Chorus Line.
 - Bennett worked with Sondheim, Hal Prince, Bob Avian, Tommy Tune and many more stars. His work spanned a variety of dance styles including tap, ballet, jazz, and chorus numbers.
 - 1976: A Chorus Line is nominated for 10 Tonys and wins 9, including Bennett’s direction and choreography, and a Pulitzer for Drama. At only 32, Bennett became a Broadway institution.
 - 1987: Bennett tragically passes away from AIDS-related symptoms

- Major productions: Company, Follies, Coco, Hallelujah, A Chorus Line, Dreamgirls

Although many anticipate the “rock musical” to take over Broadway in the 1970s, that was not quite the case. MacDermot and Guare’s Hair set the expectation which was furthered by their 1971 take on Two Gentlemen of Verona with Andrew Lloyd Webber’s smash-hit Jesus Christ Superstar in the same year, however, Broadway producers became risk-averse after a series of rock musical flops. It would take over 20 years before another successful rock musical would reinvigorate the form (RENT in 1996). But it is worth looking at some of the most successful Pop/Rock musicals of the last 3 decades of the 20th Century. [Link to slideshow](#)

1970s Pop/Rock Musicals:

- Jesus Christ Superstar (1971)
 - Music by Andrew Lloyd Webber, lyrics by Tim Rice
 - Ran for 711 performances
- Two Gentlemen of Verona (1971)
 - Music by Galt MacDermot, lyrics by John Guare, book by Guare and Mel Shapiro
 - Ran for 627 performances
 - Tony Award for Best Musical
- The Rocky Horror Show (1975)
 - Music/lyrics/book by Richard O’Brien
 - Ran only 45 performances but now a cult classic
- [The Wiz](#) (1975)
 - Music/lyrics by Charlie Smalls, book by William F. Brown
 - All-Black cast
 - Ran 1,672 performances

Influential musical theatre figures from the decade:

- Stephen Schwartz (born 1948): born in NYC to Jewish parents, Schwartz began composing music for Pippin while at Carnegie Mellon University. Schwartz has had a huge impact on Broadway writing some of the most recognizable musicals to date. By age 26 in the mid 1970s, Schwartz had 3 successful shows on Broadway at the same time: Pippin, Godspell, and the Magic Show. He has collaborated with a number of musical theatre icons including Leonard Bernstein and Alan Menken.
 - Frequently writes music for movies, including Disney productions.
 - Still working having written the music/lyrics for Queen of Versailles (2015)
 - Winner of 3 Oscars, 3 Grammys, 4 Drama Desks, but still NO Tony Award!
 - Major productions: Pippin, Godspell, The Magic Show, The Baker’s Wife, Children of Eden, The Prince of Egypt, Wicked
- Andrew Lloyd Webber (born 1948): born in London, Webber is potentially the first major composer born outside of the United States of the 20th Century. Webber’s musicals are grand, sweeping, maximalist epics that continue to dominate the musical theatre canon.

Similarly to Schwartz, Webber came to prominence on Broadway (and the West End) in the 70s. Webber's musicals are famous for being largely sung-through with very little dialogue. In addition, Webber introduces the concept of the mega-musical which is exactly how it sounds: a musical of epic proportions through content, spectacle, and amount of collaborators involved. Webber's music cuts through the pop/rock of the 1970s and reinvigorates musical theatre in the popular music zeitgeist. Many of his songs stand on their own including, "Memory" from Cats, "Music of the Night" from Phantom of the Opera, and "Don't Cry for Me, Argentina" from Evita.

- Webber's influence can be seen to this day on Broadway, the West End, Hollywood, and TV. His musicals are frequently reimagined and reproduced as star vehicles, i.e. Cynthia Erivo in The Hollywood Bowl's production of [Jesus Christ Superstar](#)
 - As for reimagined productions, [The Jellicle Ball](#) is a reimagining of Cats and has enjoyed a successful run Off-Broadway. In fact, it will see a Broadway opening in 2026
- Webber also revolutionized Broadway and the West End as not simply places to see musical theatre, but as a capitalist enterprise. Webber's musicals have broken box office records, inspired national and international tours, and The Phantom of the Opera holds the record for longest-running Broadway production at 13,981 performances.
- Winner of 7 Tony Awards, 3 Grammys, and 1 Oscar.
- Major productions: Jesus Christ Superstar, Cats, The Phantom of the Opera, Joseph and the Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat, Evita, Sunset Boulevard

1980s Pop/Rock Musicals:

- Evita (technically 1979)
 - Music by Andrew Lloyd Webber, lyrics by Tim Rice
 - Ran for 1,567 performances
 - 3 Tony Awards
- Joseph...Dreamcoat (1982)
 - Music by Webber, lyrics by Rice
 - Ran for 747 performances
- Starlight Express (1987)
 - Music by Webber, lyrics by Rice
 - Ran for 761 performances but did not make a profit
- The Phantom of the Opera (1988)
 - Music by Webber, lyrics by Rice
 - Ran 13,981 performances, grossing over \$6 billion worldwide
- [Dreamgirls](#) (1981)
 - Music by Henry Krieger, lyrics by Tom Eyrn
 - Ran 1,521 performances
 - 1 Tony Award
- Little Shop of Horrors (1982)

- Music by Alan Menken, lyrics by Howard Ashman
- Ran for 2,209 performances Off-Broadway

Influential musical theatre figures from the decade:

- Alan Menken (born 1949): born to a show business family in NYC. Menken has cemented himself as the “Disney Composer” having written the score/lyrics to several films including The Little Mermaid, Beauty and the Beast, Aladdin, Pocahontas, Newsies, Hunchback of Notre Dame, Hercules, Enchanted, Tangled. He is the second most prolific Oscar winner in music categories after Alfred Newman.
 - First Broadway success in 1979 with Little Shop of Horrors.
 - Winner of 8 Oscars, 1 Tony Award, 11 Grammys. 1 of 21 people to EGOT (win an Emmy, Grammy Oscar, and Tony)
 - Major stage productions: Little Shop of Horrors, Beauty and the Beast, Sister Act, Leap of Faith, A Bronx Tale, The Little Mermaid, Newsies

1990s Pop/Rock Musicals:

- The Lion King (1997)
 - Music by Elton John, lyrics by Tim Rice, directed by Julie Taymor
 - Still running on Broadway
 - Tony Award for Best Musical
- Once on this Island (1990)
 - Lyrics/book by Lynn Ahrens, music by Stephen Flaherty
 - Ran 469 performances
- [Hedwig and the Angry Inch](#) (1998)
 - Music by John Cameron Mitchell, lyrics by Stephen Trask
 - Ran 857 performances
 - Has become a cult-classic with several revivals
- Jelly's Last Jam (1992)
 - Book/direction by George C. Wolfe, music by Jelly Roll Morton, lyrics by Susan Birkenhead
 - Ran 569 performances
- The Who's Tommy (1992)
 - Music and lyrics by Pete Townshend
 - Ran 899 performances
 - 2 Tony Awards
- RENT (1996)
 - Music/lyrics/book by Jonathan Larson
 - Nominated for 10 Tony Awards, winning 4. Won the Pulitzer for Drama
 - Ran for 5,123 performances
 - Many national and international tours

The 1990s introduced something that has become increasingly popular in musical theatre: music by pop artists either from their discography or completely original songs that benefit from

their star power. For example: Pete Townshend from The Who, Jelly Roll Morton, and Elton John all infused their own pop music into their musicals.

Influential musical theatre figures from the decade:

- Elton John (born 1947): born in the UK where he went on to become one of the most famous rock artists ever. After decades of creating mostly pop music, Elton John began writing scores for the film, *The Lion King* in 1994. John soon moved into musical theatre once Disney began dominating Broadway stages.
 - The 19th person to EGOT, winning the Tony Award for best music for *Aida*.
 - Major productions: *The Lion King*, *Aida*, *Billy Elliot*
- Julie Taymor (born 1952): directs in theatre, opera, and film. Studied puppetry in Indonesia. All of her productions have a unique Taymore-design that is recognizable, follows in the footsteps of Hal Prince.
 - First woman to receive the Tony Award for best direction of a musical, *The Lion King*. Also served as the costume co-designer for the production which features dozens of complex puppets.
 - Major productions: *The Tempest*, *The Lion King*, *Spider-Man: Turn Off the Dark*, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, *M. Butterfly*
- George C. Wolfe (born 1954): grew up gay in Kentucky, eventually moved to NYC and started Off-Broadway in the 80s. Gained a strong national reputation for his work on the musical *Jelly's Last Jam* and the play *Angels in America*. Served as the artistic director for The Public Theater (the first Off-Broadway house in NYC) and works as a librettist for musicals.
 - Major productions: *Jelly's Last Jam*, *The Wild Party*, *Shuffle Along* (librettist), [Bring in 'da Noise, Bring in 'da Funk](#), *On the Town*, *Shuffle Along* (director)
- Susan Stroman (born 1954): an influential director/choreographer who has helped shape some of the most famous and recognizable musical theatre productions. Stroman first toured in the first national tour of *Chicago* and became friends with Kander/Ebb. Rose to prominence when she directed a revival of [Show Boat in 1994](#), utilizing innovative dance montages to guide audiences through the complicated material.
 - Main claim to fame is directing/choreographing *The Producers* (2001) which set and holds the record for most Tony Award wins (12). Became the first woman to win both director and choreographer Tonys.
 - First woman to choreograph a full-length ballet for NYC Ballet.
 - Frequent collaborators: Mel Brooks, Hal Prince, Nathan Lane, Kander/Ebb
 - Major productions: *And the World Goes Round*, *Crazy For You*, *Show Boat*, *A Christmas Carol*, *Big, Oklahoma!*, *The Music Man*, *The Producers*, *Young Frankenstein*, *The Scottsboro Boys*, *Bullets Over Broadway*, *Big Fish*
- Lynn Ahrens (born 1948) and Stephen Flaherty (born 1960): an impactful composer/lyricist team that continues to churn out big, powerful, and political musical theatre productions. Together, they have written 13 musicals.

- Winner of 2 Tony Awards, Best Musical for Ragtime and Best Revival for Once on this Island. Nominated for many other awards.
- Major productions: Lucky Stiff, Once on this Island, My Favorite Year, Ragtime, Seussical, Rocky the Musical, Anastasia
- Graciela Daniele (born 1939): born in Buenos Aires, Argentina and began dancing at 7 years old. Inspired by West Side Story in Paris and decided to pursue musical theatre. Moved to NYC and worked with Fosse, de Mille, and Bennett (who she assisted on Follies). Frequent collaborator with Ahrens and Flaherty. Directed the early iterations of the popular musical, Falsettos.
 - Added Spanish lyrics to the 1978 production of Working
 - Nominated for 10 Tony Awards but never won
 - Received Tony Award for Lifetime Achievement in the Theatre (2020)
 - Major productions: The Visit, [Annie Get Your Gun revival](#), Ragtime, Once on this Island, Mystery of Edwin Drood, The Pirates of Penzance
- Jonathan Larson (1960-1996): major influences were Elton John, The Who, Billy Joel, and Stephen Sondheim. Went to Adelphi University in NYC and saw some success with an original musical upon graduating. Worked in the Off-Broadway world for several years. RENT went through years of edits after the first staged reading in 1993 at the New York Theatre Workshop. Tragically died the night before the first preview performance of RENT. The show had a major cultural impact by bringing sensitive subjects to audiences including: AIDS, drug addiction, trans identity, and queer relationships. RENT reinvigorated the rock musical in the 1990s which has inspired many similar musicals both in their tone, themes, and musicality (i.e. Spring Awakening, Next to Normal)

The New Millennium

In Act II of RENT, Roger sings “you’re living in America, at the end of the millennium, you’re living in America, where it’s like the twilight zone” and that certainly feels apt regarding the immense changes that occur in American culture after 9/11 and the digital age. Much of this New Millennium of musical theatre, and performance more broadly, is still being written. This section looks at the first two decades of the 21st Century, the iconic productions that dominate show business, the creatives that influenced musical theatre, and what changed (or didn’t) after the year 2020.

Without question, musical theatre in the 2000s became more inclusive both in the stories it told and the people telling them. For much of the 20th Century, musical theatre was dominated by white, cis, mostly Jewish men. However, as culture became more accepting and diversity became seen as a benefit rather than a drawback, musical theatre reflected that shift in the shows that were produced on Broadway, the West End, tours, and regional theatre. And as the New Millennium brings about advancements in technology and culture, musical theatre continues to reflect on its history, interrogate its roots, and influence culture around the world.

Below is an incomplete list of select musicals, creatives, themes, and stars that had a huge impact on musical theatre.

Queer Identity on Broadway

In today's world, it may seem hard to imagine that musical theatre was not always open to queer artists or stories but that was the case throughout much of the 20th Century. Many creatives, like Bernstein and Hart, hid their sexuality from the public and carried on relationships with men in private. Yet, as the 20th Century came to a close, musical theatre artists began bringing queer stories to Broadway and beyond. What precipitated this shift and how did it come to be?

- After WWII, a more homogenous view of America took hold on Broadway and in Hollywood. Musical theatre creators wrote stories about the White, Anglo-Saxon, Protestant world (think Lerner/Loewe musicals). However, after the Stonewall Riots in 1969 and the Sexual Revolution, activists pushed for more queer representation (which meant cis white gay men in the 70s and 80s).
- As is the case in a Capitalist society, producers saw the potential to make money off musicals that represented minority groups and thereby tapping into a new market.
- Although, portraying gay and queer characters on stage is nothing new (especially men in drag), creators began writing gay characters with more depth and story
 - 1975: *A Chorus Line* premieres which features an openly gay character who gives a powerful and heart-wrenching monologue
- Jerry Herman supercharged this with his show *La Cage Aux Folles* in 1983.
 - Often deemed the “first Broadway homosexual musical” *La Cage* presents the two leading roles as gay men navigating their relationship.
 - It was groundbreaking for its time but still left a lot to be desired by upholding classic gay stereotypes, the two gay men never sharing a kiss, and the story revolving around a heterosexual wedding. Indeed, the chorus is comprised of performers in drag but does little to move forward the art of drag or even comment on trans identity
- Sadly, the HIV/AIDS epidemic severely complicates the portrayal of queer characters because creators are unsure of how audiences will react to the themes or struggles therein. The reactionary view of HIV/AIDS in America makes the public far more judgmental of queer identity in popular entertainment.
- Although the HIV/AIDS crisis continued throughout the 90s, stories about queer people broke through. Gay characterizations were more realistic and less stereotypical than in the previous two decades.
 - Sexuality no longer became the defining trait of characters.
 - Work emerges that dramatizes stories of individuals living with AIDS
 - Portrayals of lesbians finally make it to Broadway
- Musicals about the HIV/AIDS epidemic also emerge. Some are deeply touching, others are wryly and darkly comedic. These were ways of coping with a disease that ravaged the musical theatre community.

- Elegies for Angels, Punks, and Raging Queens (1989)
- An Unfinished Song (1991)
- Falsettos (1992)
- All That He Was (1993)
- AIDS - The Musical (1995)

As is the way with all things, progress is made and shows that were once revolutionary appear outdated as time passes. It is important to recognize shows for what they were at the time – to go from seeing gay men on stage, to seeing them kiss, to seeing them navigate their relationships, to caring about them as people and not reducing them to their identity, to expanding gay identity to queer identity and widening the tent of stories to tell – all of this works in service of being more progressive and expansive about the stories we tell. Below is a list of some musicals that involved gay characters or stories that, without question, influenced the queer work today.

- The Producers, Spamalot, Rock of Ages, Lysistrata Joes, The Drowsy Chaperone, Legally Blonde, Mrs. Doubtfire, and more...
- Additionally, the New Millennium brings musicals specifically about lesbians including: The Color Purple (2005), Fun Home (2015), and The Prom (2018). As well as genderqueer/non-binary/trans stories including: Jagged Little Pill (2018), Head Over Heels (2018), & Juliet (2022).

One major development throughout the fight for queer representation on Broadway was the creation of Broadway Cares/Equity Fights AIDS. This is a nonprofit organization that raises funds for AIDS-related causes across the US.

Here's a brief history:

- 1987: Actors' Equity Association (AEA) founded Equity Fights AIDS
- 1988: The Producers' Group founded Broadway Cares
- 1992: the groups merge
- 1993: received an honorary Tony Award for Excellence in Theatre
- Each fall season on Broadway, there is an informal competition between all shows to see which can raise the most money. Actors stand with buckets for donations outside of shows.
- 1992: Broadway Bares: an annual burlesque fundraiser founded by Jerry Mitchell

As is the case in all eras of musical theatre, new terms emerge to describe the changing artistic landscape.

- Post-millennial musical theatre: the literature is intimate, emotionally present, and focused on storytelling. Includes songs that move the plot ahead with needs/desires
 - Oftentimes songs fit both within a narrative and in a cabaret or stand-alone setting. I.e. [Jason Robert Brown music](#)

- Legit shows: music and singing that is more classical than “Broadway musical theatre style.” But can be in both musical theatre and opera. This style has been around since the antecedents but never received a designation.
 - [2012 Porgy and Bess revival](#)
- Contemporary mix: the score highlights more variety in singing styles including legit, pop/rock, and everything in between
 - Singers: Norbert Leo Butz, Sutton Foster, Brian D’arcy James, Renee Elise Goldsberry, Idina Menzel, Phillipa Soo

In addition to previous decades, musicals of the 2000s reflect the popular music of the time and an explosion of jukebox musicals hit the stage. Here is a brief list:

2000s Jukebox Musicals

- **Mamma Mia (2001)**
 - Music by ABBA
 - Ran 5,773 performances
 - A revival currently running on Broadway (2025)
- **All Shook Up (2005)**
 - Inspired by the music by Elvis Presley
 - Ran 213 performances
- **Jersey Boys (2005)**
 - Music by Frankie Valli and the Four Seasons
 - Ran for 4,093 performances
 - Extremely popular in regional theatres and tours
- **Rock of Ages (2006)**
 - Music by various glam rock 80’s bands
 - Ran for 2,328 performances
 - Popular on cruise ships and tours

One pop/rock-style musical to highlight from this period is [Passing Strange](#) (2008) by Stew. It combines Stew’s music with his lived experience as a Black performer traveling around the world. He was fascinated by Elizabethan English audiences watching Shakespeare plays and the rowdy relationship between performer and audience. He decided to combine that energy with a rock show. The musical touches on themes and cultural references mentioned throughout this toolkit history:

- Josephine Baker living as an ex-pat in Berlin, entertainer, activist, and fashion icon. Richard Wright is known for his works *Black Boy*, *Native Son*, and *Uncle Tom’s Children*. James Baldwin, writer and activist known for his works *Giovanni’s Room* and *Go Tell it on the Mountain*.

- Themes include: Black identity, Life vs. Art, The “real” (youth in search of meaning), and Youth vs. Experience.
- These references and themes reflect pop/rock music as well as musical theatre turning a mirror onto society

The 2010s continue relatively in the same vein as the 2000s. Pop/rock musicals continue to dominate Broadway. It would be a disservice not to mention the musical that cracked open the zeitgeist and became the most popular cultural hit in decades. Of course, that would be the 2015 musical, *Hamilton*. With music, lyrics, and a book by Lin-Manuel Miranda, *Hamilton* went through years of workshopping at Vassar College, and small theaters around NYC. [Miranda sang his first rendition of “Alexander Hamilton” in 2009 at the White House.](#) The show premiered Off-Broadway but quickly transferred to the Richard Rodgers Theatre on Broadway in 2015. It became an immediate smash-hit and garnered 16 Tony Nominations (a first for any musical), winning 11 including Best Musical, Best Book, Best Score, as well as winning the Pulitzer Prize for Drama. Since then, *Hamilton* has produced several national and international tours including in Puerto Rico, Australia, the West End, Hamburg, and was even filmed and is available for streaming on Disney. A little bit about the creators:

- Lin-Manuel Miranda (born 1980): grew up in NYC but spent time in Puerto Rico. First Broadway show was *In the Heights* in 2008. Similarly to *Hamilton*, Miranda began work years earlier with his collaborator, Tommy Kail. *In the Heights* saw out of town tryouts in Connecticut before moving Off-Broadway in 2007. It was nominated for 13 Tony Awards, winning 4 including Best Musical. Miranda frequently stars in his own shows. He has since become a major composer and works frequently with Disney having acted and written for *Moana*, *Mary Poppins Returns*, *Encanto*, *The Little Mermaid*. Directed the film version of Jonathan Larson’s *Tick...Tick...Boom!*
- Thomas “Tommy” Kail (born 1977): a closer collaborator of Lin-Manuel Miranda. Co-created the freestyle hip-hop group Freestyle Love Supreme with LMM. Received his first Broadway directorial experience with *A Bus Stop Play*. Directed *The Wiz* in 2009 and *Lombardi* in 2010. Was part of *Hamilton* from the very beginning and won the Tony for Best Director. Other major productions: *Tiny Beautiful Things*, *Magic/Bird*, *Freestyle Love Supreme*, *Sweeney Todd* (2023 revival)
- Andy Blankenbuehler (born 1970): started as a dancer on Broadway in *Guys and Dolls*, *Fosse*, *Man of La Mancha*, *Saturday Night Fever* and more. A frequent collaborator of LMM and Kail, choreographed for *In the Heights* and *Hamilton*, winning Tonys for both. Other work includes: *9 to 5*, *Annie* (2012 revival), *The Wiz*, *Bandstand*.

and more jukebox musicals are brought to the Great White Way and The West End. In addition to rock groups, solo artists also start seeing their own musicals.

2010s Pop/Rock and Jukebox Musical

- The Bodyguard (2012)
 - Music of Whitney Houston
 - Originally opened in the UK on the West End. Has seen a variety of international tours and sit-down productions.
 - Never had a Broadway run
- Beautiful: The Carole King Musical (2013)
 - Music of Carole King
 - Ran for 2,418 performances on Broadway
- On Your Feet! (2015)
 - Music by Emilio and Gloria Estefan
 - Ran 746 performances on Broadway
- Summer: The Donna Summer Musical (2017)
 - Music of Donna Summer
 - Ran 289 performances
- Escape to Margaritaville (2018)
 - Music by Jimmy Buffet
 - Ran 124 performances
- The Cher Show (2018)
 - Music of Cher
 - Ran 296 performances

The New Millennium not only sees a rise in pop/rock and jukebox musicals, it also sees an explosion of screen-to-stage musical adaptations. Producers see this as a fantastic way to make incredible box office revenue by adapting beloved movies into musicals with a built-in fanbase (similar to a star vehicle production). One of the powerhouses in this field is The Walt Disney Company. Disney Theatrical was founded in 1993 ahead of the 1994 Broadway production of *Beauty and the Beast*. Since then, Disney Theatrical has produced 10 adaptations of animated movies and around 5 live-action adaptations on Broadway. Not to mention, dozens of musicals on their fleet of cruise ships operated by [Disney Cruise Line](#). Apart from Disney, there have been countless screen-to-stage adaptations on Broadway and around the world.

An incomplete list of screen-to-stage adaptations:

- Monty Python's Spamalot (2005)
- Aladdin (2014)
- An American in Paris (2015)
- Newsies (2012)
- Bridges of Madison County (2013)
- Dirty Rotten Scoundrels (2005)
- Thoroughly Modern Millie (2002)
- Xanadu (2007)
- Once (2012)
- School of Rock (2015)
- Hairspray (2002)

- Pretty Woman (2017)
- Mrs. Doubtfire (2020)
- Tootsie (2018)
- Elf (2010)
- Ghost (2011)
- Frozen (2018)
- Death Becomes Her (2024)

An incomplete list of influential musical theatre figures in the New Millennium:

Composers/lyricists:

Benj Pasek (born 1985) and Justin Paul (born 1985): Best known for their works, *The Greatest Showman*, *Dear Evan Hansen* and producing *A Strange Loop*.

Toby Marlow (born 1994) and Lucy Moss (born 1994): Best known for their hit musical, *Six*, for which they won a Tony Award for Best Original Score.

Tom Kitt (born 1974) and Brian Yorkey (born 1971): Best known for their works: *Next To Normal* (winner of the Pulitzer Prize for Drama), *Bring It On*, *If/Then*, *Freaky Friday*, *Almost Famous*.

Sara Bareilles (born 1979): toured with Counting Crows and Maroon 5. Best known for adapting the film *Waitress* into a musical in 2015. Composer/lyricist and lead performer in the Broadway production. Performance credits include: *The Little Mermaid*, *Jesus Christ Superstar*, and *Into the Woods*.

Jason Robert Brown (born 1970): composer, lyricist, and playwright. First major NY production was *Songs for a New World*, directed by Daisy Prince (daughter of Hal Prince). Other major productions: *Parade*, *The Last Five Years*, *13*, *Bridges of Madison County*, *Honeymoon in Vegas*, *Mr. Saturday Night*. Winner of 2 Tony Awards.

Michael R. Jackson (born 1981): Composer, lyricist, playwright for *A Strange Loop* which won 2 Tony Awards and the Pulitzer Prize in 2020. Other work: *Big, Black & Queer American Musical!* Which opened in 2022 after being disrupted by COVID in 2020.

Jeanine Tesori (born 1961): the most prolific and honored female theatrical composer in history. First Broadway gig was arranging music for *How to Succeed in Business Without Really Trying*. Major productions: *Fun Home* (first all-female composing team, winner of 2 Tony Awards), *Thoroughly Modern Millie*, *Caroline, or Change*, *Shrek: the Musical*, *Soft Power*, *Kimberly Akimbo*.

David Lindsay-Abaire (born 1969): known primarily for his Pulitzer-winning play, *Rabbit Hole*, Lindsay-Abaire has written the books for several musicals including: *High Fidelity*, *Shrek: the Musical*, and *Kimberly Akimbo*

David Henry Hwang (born 1957): although his career has spanned over 4 decades, Hwang's popularity rose in the 2000s when he co-wrote the book for *Aida* in 2000 and worked on a radical revision of Rodgers & Hammerstein's [Flower Drum Song](#) in 2002. Other musical works include: *Tarzan* and *Soft Power*.

Adam Guettel (born 1964): Composer and lyricist recognized for sophisticated, classically influenced musical theatre scores. Best known for *Floyd Collins*, *The Light in the Piazza* (winner of the Tony Award for Best Original Score), and *Days of Wine and Roses*. Grandson of composer Richard Rodgers, Guettel is noted for complex harmonies, emotionally rich storytelling, and expanding the musical language of contemporary Broadway.

Directors:

Diane Paulus (born 1966): a background in avant-garde theatre, Paulus's career spans decades. Third woman to win Tony Award for Best Direction of a Musical for *Pippin*. First major production to cast a female in the role of Lead Player, traditionally cast as a male performer. Helped secure an all-female production team for *Waitress*. Major productions: *Porgy and Bess*, *Pippin*, *Finding Neverland*, *Waitress*, *Jagged Little Pill*

Marianne Elliott (born 1966): UK theatre director who works on both musicals and plays. Many of her productions begin in the West End and transfer to Broadway, including the recent revival of *Company*. She played an instrumental role in casting the traditionally-male "Bobby" as a female "Bobbi" which gained an incredible amount of praise from theatre critics (including Sondheim himself). 3 Tony Awards for Best Director.

Joe Mantello (born 1962): got his start as an actor in *Angels in America* directed by George C. Wolfe. Has since made his way into directing with productions: *Wicked*, *Assassins* (Tony Award for Best Director), *Pal Joey* revival, *9 to 5*.

Casey Nicholaw (born 1966): a director/choreographer combo who has won 2 Tony Awards and worked on a variety of shows. Initially worked with Stroman on *Crazy For You*. Major productions: *Spamalot*, *The Drowsy Chaperone*, *The Book of Mormon*, *Aladdin*, *Something Rotten!*, *Mean Girls*, *The Prom*, *Some Like It Hot*

Jerry Mitchell (born 1960: started as a dancer on Broadway in *The Will Rogers Follies* and *Brigadoon*. Director/choreographer credits include: *Hairspray*, *Legally Blonde*, *Kinky Boots*, *On Your Feet!*, *Pretty Woman*. Directs the annual Broadway Bares event through Broadway Cares/Equity Fights AIDS

Rob Marshall (born 1960): started out as a dancer in various Broadway shows but suffered an injury while in *Cats*. Known for directing stage-to-screen musicals such as *Chicago*, *Into the Woods*, *Mary Poppins Returns*, *The Little Mermaid*. Director/choreographer for musical theatre: *Kiss of the Spider Woman*, *Damn Yankees*, *She Loves Me*, [Cabaret \(1998 revival\)](#)

Kathleen Marshall (born 1962): got her start assisting her brother on musicals. Tony Award for Best Choreography for *Wonderful Town*, *The Pajama Game*, and *Anything Goes*. Other credits: *1776*, *Kiss Me, Kate*, *Kiss of the Spider Woman*, *She Loves Me*, *Nice Work if You Can Get it*, *In Transit*

Jamie Lloyd (born 1980): British director known for bold, minimalist reinterpretations of classic musicals and plays. Directed acclaimed productions of *Sunset Boulevard*, *Cyrano de Bergerac*, *Betrayal*, *A Doll's House*, and *Evita*. Founder of the Jamie Lloyd Company, celebrated for highly stylized staging, contemporary aesthetics, and actor-centered performances.

Performers:

Bernadette Peters (born 1948): Born in Queens, NY, known for her major roles: Dot in *Sunday in the Park with George*, the Witch in *Into the Woods*, and Annie Oakley in *Annie Get Your Gun*. A favorite of Stephen Sondheim, Peters is considered one of the defining interpreters of his work. She has won two Tony Awards and a special Tony for lifetime achievement.

Audra McDonald (born 1970): Raised in Fresno, CA and trained at Juilliard, McDonald is a six-time Tony Award winner — more than any other actor. Her major roles include *Carousel*, *Ragtime*, *A Raisin in the Sun*, and *Porgy and Bess*. She originated the role of Sarah in *Ragtime* and Bess in *Porgy and Bess* on Broadway. Recently lauding praise as Mama Rose in *Gypsy*.

Patti LuPone (born 1949): Originated the role of Eva Perón in *Evita*, for which she won her first Tony. Other major roles: *Gypsy*, *Company*, *Sunset Boulevard* (London), *Anything Goes*, *Sweeney Todd*. LuPone is outspoken and has become a Broadway legend with a passionate fan base.

Angela Lansbury (1925–2022): Born in London, moved to the U.S. during WWII. Film debut in *Gaslight* (1944), earning an Oscar nomination at 19. Had a second career on Broadway beginning in the 1960s. Major roles: Mame in *Mame*, Mrs. Lovett in *Sweeney Todd*, and Mamma Rose in *Gypsy*. Won 5 Tony Awards. Voiced Mrs. Potts in Disney's *Beauty and the Beast*.

Nathan Lane (born 1956): a Broadway veteran known for his comedic timing. Breakthrough came as Max Bialystock in *The Producers*, for which he won a Tony Award (2001). Also starred in *A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum*, *The Nance*, *Angels in America*, *Guys and Dolls*, *The Front Page*. He has won three Tony Awards.

Renée Elise Goldsberry (born 1971): Gained recognition as Angelica Schuyler in *Hamilton*, winning a Tony in 2016 for Best Featured Actress. Other credits: *The Color Purple*, *RENT*, *Good People*, *The Lion King*.

Phillipa Soo (born 1990): originated the role of Eliza Hamilton in *Hamilton*, earning a Tony nomination. Also starred in *Amélie*, *The Parisian Woman*, and *Camelot*.

Mandy Patinkin (born 1952): Chicago-born, Patinkin's Broadway debut was *Evita* (opposite LuPone), for which he won a Tony. Other major stage roles include *Sunday in the Park with George* and *The Wild Party*.

Norm Lewis (born 1963): made history as the first Black actor to play the Phantom in *The Phantom of the Opera* on Broadway. Other major roles: *Porgy and Bess*, *Les Misérables*, *Once on This Island*, *Sweeney Todd*.

Cynthia Erivo (born 1987): British-born performer who rose to fame playing Celie in *The Color Purple* on Broadway, winning the Tony, Grammy, and Emmy for her performance. Transitioned into film with *Harriet* and the film adaptation of *Wicked*. Recently performed in *Jesus Christ Superstar* at the Hollywood Bowl.

Lea Salonga (born 1971): Born in the Philippines, Salonga gained international fame as Kim in *Miss Saigon*, for which she won a Tony — the first Asian woman to do so. Also known for *Les Misérables*, *Allegiance*, and *Once on This Island*. Provided the singing voices for Disney's *Jasmine* (*Aladdin*) and *Mulan*.

Liza Minnelli (born 1946): Daughter of Judy Garland and director Vincente Minnelli. Rose to fame in *Cabaret* (film), winning an Oscar for her performance. Broadway credits include *Flora the Red Menace*, *The Act*, *The Rink*, and *Liza's at the Palace*. Known for her explosive stage presence, powerhouse vocals, and deeply personal connection to performance. A star in film, TV, and concerts.

Harvey Fierstein (born 1952): Known for his gravelly voice and unique writing style, Fierstein broke through with *Torch Song Trilogy*, which he wrote and starred in. Won Tonys as both actor and playwright. Also wrote the books for *La Cage aux Folles*, *Kinky Boots*, *Newsies*, *A Catered Affair*. As an actor, starred in *Hairspray*, *Fiddler on the Roof*. A major advocate for LGBTQ+ visibility on stage.

Idina Menzel (born 1971): Broadway debut as Maureen in *RENT* (1996). Achieved superstardom as Elphaba in *Wicked* (2003), winning a Tony for her performance. Later originated roles in *If/Then* and starred in *Skintight*. Voice of Elsa in Disney's *Frozen*.

Bebe Neuwirth (born 1958): Trained as a dancer, Neuwirth made her Broadway debut in *A Chorus Line* and won Tonys for *Sweet Charity* and *Chicago* (Velma Kelly). Other Broadway credits include *The Addams Family*, *Fosse*, and *A Chorus Line*.

Kelli O'Hara (born 1976): Nominated for 7 Tony Awards, winning for *The King and I* (2015). Other major roles: *The Light in the Piazza*, *South Pacific*, *Bridges of Madison County*, *Kiss Me, Kate*. Also performs in opera (*The Hours* at the Met) and frequently appears in concerts.

Gary Beach (1947–2018): Known for his comedic flair, Beach won a Tony for his role as Roger De Bris in *The Producers* (2001). Other Broadway credits include *Beauty and the Beast*, *La Cage aux Folles*, and *Annie*. Reprised his *Producers* role in the 2005 film adaptation.

Raúl Esparza (born 1970): Notable Broadway roles include *Company* (Bobby), *Taboo*, *The Homecoming*, *Leap of Faith*, and *Chitty Chitty Bang Bang*. Received four Tony nominations. A strong interpreter of Sondheim with a commanding vocal range.

Elaine Stritch (1925–2014): Broadway icon known for her brassy persona and sharp comic timing. Key performances include *Company* (Joanne), *A Delicate Balance*, *Sail Away*, *Bus Stop*, and *A Little Night Music*. Won a Tony for her one-woman show *Elaine Stritch at Liberty*.

Joel Grey (born 1932): Born into a vaudeville family, Grey's breakout came as the Emcee in Cabaret — a role he originated on Broadway and reprised in the film, winning both a Tony and an Oscar. Also starred in George M!, Wicked (as the original Wizard), and Chicago. Directed The Normal Heart on Broadway.

Angelica Ross (born 1980): made her Broadway debut as Roxie Hart in Chicago in 2022, becoming one of the first openly transgender women to star in a leading role on Broadway. Best known for her roles on screen in Pose and American Horror Story. Founder of TransTech Social Enterprises, she is also a leading voice for trans rights and representation in entertainment.

L Morgan Lee (born 1980): Made history as the first openly transgender actor to be nominated for a Tony Award, for her role as Thought 1 in A Strange Loop (2022). Lee began her career in regional theater and international tours. She's also a vocal advocate for trans visibility in the arts and has appeared in numerous panels and events supporting LGBTQ+ artists.

Chita Rivera (1933–2024): Legendary performer and one of Broadway's greatest dancers. Originated iconic roles in West Side Story (Anita), Bye Bye Birdie (Rose Alvarez), Chicago (Velma Kelly), and Kiss of the Spider Woman (Aurora), winning two Tony Awards. Known for her fierce stage presence, athletic choreography, and long collaboration with directors and choreographers such as Jerome Robbins and Bob Fosse.

Alex Newell (born 1992): Actor and singer celebrated for a powerhouse voice and groundbreaking achievements in musical theatre. Rose to prominence through Glee before starring on Broadway in Once on This Island and Shucked, winning a Tony Award for Shucked and becoming one of the first openly nonbinary performers to receive the honor. Known for dynamic vocal performances blending gospel, pop, and musical theatre traditions.

Leslie Odom Jr. (born 1981): Best known for originating the role of Aaron Burr in Hamilton, earning the Tony Award for Best Actor in a Musical. Also appeared in Rent, Leap of Faith, and Purlie Victorious. Acclaimed for his smooth baritone voice, nuanced acting style, and successful crossover career in film, television, and jazz performance.

Jennifer Hudson (born 1981): Singer and actress who transitioned from American Idol finalist to award-winning stage and screen performer. Won an Academy Award for portraying Effie White in the film adaptation of Dreamgirls and later appeared in Broadway's The Color Purple. One of the few entertainers to achieve EGOT status.

Tommy Tune (born 1939): Towering Broadway performer and director-choreographer known for exuberant staging and elegant dance vocabulary. Starred in and directed productions such as Seesaw, My One and Only, Grand Hotel, Nine, and The Will Rogers Follies. Won ten Tony Awards across multiple categories, becoming one of the most decorated artists in Broadway history.

Contemporary Musical Theatre

This is the current era of musical theatre. Post-COVID, Digital Age, and short-form vertical videos currently define this ever-evolving moment. In 2020, like so many industries, live performance was all but completely shut down. Broadway closed on March 12, 2020 and remained closed for the remainder of the year. Even with the vaccine rollout in 2021, it took a long time for shows to confidently reopen their doors and for audiences to safely gather. [This](#)

[article](#) provides a glimpse into the early days of the pandemic and the subsequent efforts to keep live performance afloat. In the months and years that followed the pandemic, Broadway has seen incredible shifts both in its repertoire of shows as well as its box office revenue. One major shake-up was the 2023 announcement that *The Phantom of the Opera*, Broadway's longest-running show, would close. Since then, [shows have struggled to make a profit](#) and Broadway performers/musicians/workers are threatening to go on strike in order to advocate for fairer treatment by unions and producers.

With the rise of TikTok, Instagram Reels, and other forms of short-form vertical media, musical theatre is adapting and evolving. One innovative example born out of the 2020 Lockdown was [Ratatouille the Musical](#). It involved some high-profile creatives including Lucy Moss from *Six* fame and actor Kevin Chamberlain. This online crowd-sourced format is an example of how musical theatre could potentially intertwine itself with social media.

Musical theatre is an ongoing experiment. This toolkit provided a quick overview of the history (good, bad, and ugly). It highlights its successes, interrogates its failures, all while looking at the past in order to imagine the future. While we do not know what will happen next, we can appreciate just how greatly this artistic form has advanced over the last 150 years and work hard to make sure it continues to be a progressive, accepting, and proudly American performance medium.

Practical Assignments

1. Core Viewing Assignments (CVA): Choose as many musicals as you wish, assign viewing to students. Ask them to write a 1-page response utilizing at least 5 terms from that unit/musical.
2. Response to a live musical: Basically, an expansion of the CVAs. Expand the amount of terms required for this response. Required in-person viewing of a musical.
3. Mini Group Performance: In groups of 3-4, students pick a song from any musical and stage it using elements from the Golden Triangle. The song can be performed as a lip-sync or live with an accompaniment (depending on experience level and space)! Incorporate 3 terms from any unit in the semester.
4. Musical Jigsaw Production Concept: Throughout the semester, students will identify 4 elements from 4 different musicals that appeal to them, these could be a specific choreographer, designer, director, performer, adaptation, etc. Students then create a production concept for their own musical. This could be something totally original or an adaptation/revival of an established musical. Create a slideshow "pitch" to producers (fellow classmates) and include pictures and video.

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